

Could AI's use of water counteract Global Climate Change?

Posted by u/DavidFoxfire • 0 points • 20 comments

Here me out for a bit. I just had a crazy idea, and I don't know where I should share it. You have my word that weed was not involved in the creation of this idea.

We all know the argument that AI uses a lot of water, although not as much as a sliver compared to agricultural industries and food production, but assume it's there for this argument.

We also heard about Global Climate Change and the possibility of the ice caps melting and sea levels rising. (Something an Anti would believe religiously, your mileage can vary on this, but let's assume it's the case for this argument.)

What if...the water all these Data Centers AI uses, thanks to the water cycle we all know still exists...counteracts with the ice caps melting? Stay with me.

The ice melts into the oceans, and the water level threatens to rise...but at this point the water evaporates into vapor, is carried off by the wind, forms a cloud, and rains. The rains gets collected into springs, creeks, and eventually rivers. This is where the Data Centers get the water...and store it. That's water taken out of the water cycle, at least temporarily. *Could the water proverbially taken from the Data Center counteract the water melted into the sea and keep the water level steady?*

Again, this is just an idea popped in my head. It might not even happen like this in real life, but I'd like to hear what you'd think about this. Even if you intend to just call me crazy. Won't be the first time someone called me a loon.

Comments

u/A_Very_Horny_Zed • 1 points • 2026-03-05 22:23 UTC

Hello. This sub is a space for pro-AI activism, not debate. Your post will be removed because it is against this rule. You are welcome to post this on r/aiwars.

u/Puzzleheaded-Rope808 • 1 points • 2026-03-05 16:41 UTC

All new datacenters are closed loop systems. They do not use water. This myth is perpetuated by people who are either ignorant or have an agenda. Even the old datacenters do not "use" water. It evaporates in cooling towers creating steam...which becomes clouds...which become rain. All non-toxic.

As an engineer, this is the most mindnumbingly stupid discussion we are forced to have on a regular basis.

u/Suspicious_Log_5822 • 1 points • 2026-03-05 12:38 UTC

this might be one of the most stupid things i have heard in my life. sea level rise is not the only threat posed by climate change. climate change lowers the polar vortex causing more extreme winter storms, it increases risk of hurricanes, and it increases risk of all other severe weather events. plus, ai data centers dont delete water. they evaporate it. then, it rains back down.

sources:

<https://www.climate.gov/news-features/understanding-climate/understanding-arctic-polar-vortex>

<https://www.americanprogress.org/article/climate-change-fueled-hurricanes-are-increasingly-destructive-and-costly-for-u-s-communities>

<https://www.edf.org/climate/climate-change-and-extreme-weather>

u/graybotics • 1 points • 2026-03-05 10:02 UTC

Salt water vs fresh water are fundamentally two different materials.

u/IHeartBadCode • 3 points • 2026-03-05 09:52 UTC

I think you may be under estimating how large the ice caps are.

If all the ice caps melted completely we are looking at about 30 sextillion extra liters of water.
30,000,000,000,000,000,000.

A 100MW AI Data center on the high end is estimated to "consume" 11 million liters per day.
11,000,000. So for 365 days we're looking at 4,015,000,000 liters per year.

That would be about 750,000,000,000 data centers or roughly 93 entire data centers per person alive currently on the planet Earth.

Not to mention that at 100MW per data center we would be talking levels of power that are staggering.

So it's unlikely we could ever store all the water from ice caps in some manmade structure. The ice caps are immense in size and represent a massive volume of water compared to values of water we typically deal with.

u/Eternally_Monika • 2 points • 2026-03-05 09:38 UTC

>I just had a crazy idea

Correct

u/knight1b • 1 points • 2026-03-05 09:19 UTC

Short answer is no

u/Elegant-Pie6486 • 1 points • 2026-03-05 08:18 UTC

No, and sea levels have already been rising, these things do get measured

u/LN3000 • 10 points • 2026-03-05 07:23 UTC

People understand the water cycle, and still act like ai magically deletes water from the earth.

u/knight1b • 2 points • 2026-03-05 09:22 UTC

The water cycle exists but those fresh water sources don't magically replenish themselves there are real limits to how much water you can pull and how fast before it creates real problems.

u/water2770 • 1 points • 2026-03-05 20:30 UTC

Which is why the people selling water rights or bulk water should price appropriately instead of letting people take all the cheap water they want. So areas with higher limits are used more when water is needed or people may use alternatives.

u/abnormalredditor73 • 2 points • 2026-03-05 06:34 UTC

No.

u/Environmental-Meet22 • -6 points • 2026-03-05 06:18 UTC

that's bullshit.

data centers use drinking water because it doesn't react with the electronic devices such as transistors. if you hope to end all of the drinking water in a few years and just think that developers know water cycle, you're dumb!

u/Whilpin • 4 points • 2026-03-05 10:28 UTC

drinking water will absolutely react with electronics. your phone is sealed with IP65 rating: not waterproof, but resistant, because if water gets in, theres a 70% chance your device will die. Because water.

The problem is the ions within: chlorine, amongst many other minerals (you know, the stuff that causes your sinks and showers to look gross if you dont clean them periodically) eats away at the radiators (typically aluminum) and coldplates (typically copper), it plates the aluminum onto the copper, clogging up the tiny finstack and causing leaks.

They ****kinda**** use drinking water. It's de-ionized water. It's expensive to make, but wont cause corrosion. It's also treated with a biocide. Also incredibly expensive at the scale these centers run at. Because of this, they do not just run water through the datacenter, they take enough to fill their primary loop, and seal it. Thats it. A one-time extraction. It's too expensive to just throw away, and way cheaper to just hold onto it than to continuously draw on the water supply. That loop is then cooled via either air radiators (like a giant version of your home PC cooling loop), or cooled via a secondary loop that uses evaporative cooling (effectively a giant swamp cooler, those giant cooling stacks next to nuclear power plants? thats evaporative cooling. Not steam, but effectively a cloud machine).

"AI water use" is mostly on the power generation side.

u/Environmental-Meet22 • -1 points • 2026-03-05 10:40 UTC

but it doesn't change the fact that to cool servers t
it's involved drinking water

u/Whilpin • 2 points • 2026-03-05 10:41 UTC

Compared to neaely every other industry that uses water both directly
and indirectly, its literally a drop in the bucket.

u/Environmental-Meet22 • -1 points • 2026-03-05 11:26 UTC

say that again

How AI Demand Is Draining Local Water Supplies
<https://share.google/s4SAwwwNYhwhOh6b2>

u/Whilpin • 1 points • 2026-03-05
14:46 UTC

Sure.

ahem

Golf course.

u/[deleted]
• 1 points
• 2026-
03-05
14:49
UTC

[removed]

u/Samy_Horny • 4 points • 2026-03-05 06:08 UTC

To begin with, you should know that any data center uses that type of cooling; I don't want to sound too technical, so I'll try to explain it as simply as possible.

You have a PC, you know it has fans (there are other cooling methods but this is the most obvious one) and you also know that even your cell phone gets hot after a while.

Technology has advanced so much that processor transistors are now smaller than a human hair, and, well, passing an electric current through them to make them behave in X or Y way at speeds approaching the speed of light is going to generate heat. Basically, it's the laws of thermodynamics.

In short, and to summarize, this is the best way found to cool computers placed close together in a confined space (which is essentially what a data center is) It's basically about carrying away all that heat with a liquid, and the ideal liquid is drinking water (not salt water since the electronic compounds would have a greater chance of reacting, and water in that state is conductive).

And well, we would have died about 20 years ago since the internet started to become popular and grow. I'd heard somewhere that even the hairspray cans from those crazy '80s hairstyles did so much

damage to the ozone layer that the planet is still recovering from it. Yep, hairspray is more harmful than using water to cool servers.